



DOWNFALL BY DESIGN

With the I-League growing increasingly irrelevant, India's football structure is **faltering** at its foundations.

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The I-League, which operated as the Indian top division for 12 years between 2007 and 2019, has delivered thrilling stories and nail-biting title races. Yet, year after year, its struggles have only been compounded. Meanwhile, the Indian Super League (ISL), initially launched as a franchise tournament in 2014, became Indian football's top-flight in 2019.

Stripped of its top-tier status, coupled with poor scheduling, lack of marketing and insufficient broadcasting, the I-League has seen several clubs pushed into disarray. Since 2014, eight clubs from the league have shut down, including former champions Salgaocar FC and Chennai City FC. The I-League has borne the brunt of the All India Football Federation's (AIFF's) apathy towards its own competition.

MRA responsible for I-League misery

V. C. Praveen, the owner of Gokulam Kerala, points to the Master Rights Agreement (MRA)

signed between the AIFF and Football Sports Development Limited (FSDL) in 2010 as the root cause of the second division's predicament.

"From scheduling onwards, everything about Indian football is very poor now. The minute the MRA was signed, Indian football was killed," says Praveen. "They were only safeguarding their interest. The AIFF was very comfortable with the marketing money they were receiving, so they became very lazy."

In 2016, three Goan clubs — Dempo SC, Salgaocar FC and Sporting Clube de Goa — withdrew from the I-League, opposing the